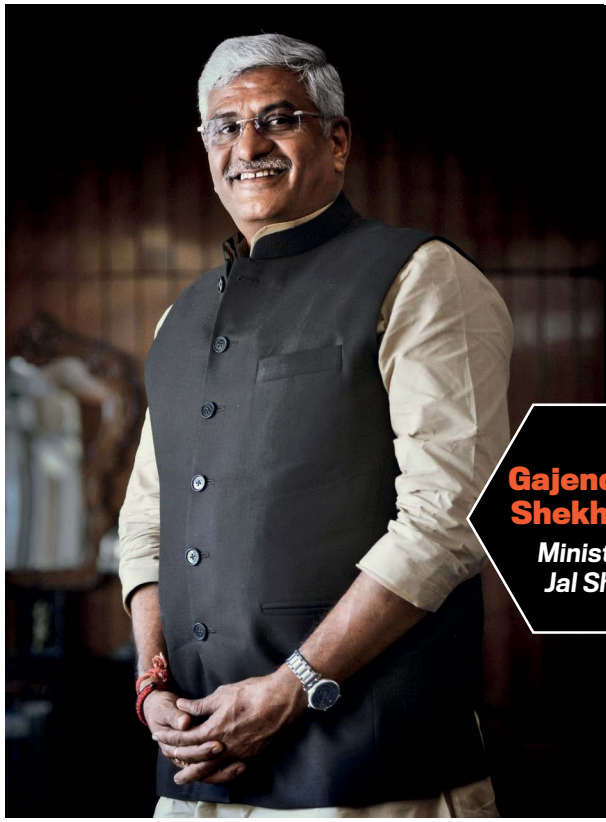


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Gajendra S. Shekhawat
Minister of Jal Shakti

Water Vows

The Jal Jeevan Mission has made a commendable effort in trying to ease India's water woes and get functional tap connections to rural households. Much work remains in other projects

By Amarnath K. Menon

THE JAL JEEVAN MISSION (JJM), the central government's flagship programme launched in 2019 to provide piped water to all homes, is on track. In the past year, as many as 21.2 million new rural households got water connections, bringing the total number to 121.5 million (as of May 31), says ministry data. JJM connections are called functional household tap connection (FHTC), qualified as at least 55 litres of water per day per person on a regular basis. This covers about 62 per cent of all rural households, up from 17 per cent when the mission was launched. While rural households in seven states and UTs had 100 per cent tap water coverage, as many as 10 states had less than 50 per cent coverage. Jharkhand (24 per cent) and Lakshadweep (0 per cent) had least coverage in the country.

With a focus on the wellbeing of children, the Jal Shakti ministry led by Gajendra Shekhawat launched a campaign in 2020 to provide tap water connections to all schools, anganwadi centres and *ashramshalas* (tribal residential schools). Tap water supply is available now in 884,000 (85.8 per cent) schools and 914,000 anganwadi centres.

Five states—Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Kerala and Telangana—and three UTs—Andaman and Nicobar islands, Puducherry and Dadra & Nagar Haveli, Daman & Diu—now provide 100 per cent tap water connectivity in schools and anganwadi centres. Another 16 states are in the range of 90 per cent or more.

So far, over 520,000 *pani samitis* (village water and sanitation committees) have been formed under JJM to manage water supply infrastructure. More than 1.7 million women have also been trained to test water samples using field test kits, leading to their empowerment in rural areas. Meanwhile, Mission Amrit Sarovar (MAS), to rejuvenate 75 water bodies in every district and create 50,000 water bodies of an acre or more each by August 2023, remains a work in progress.

The National Mission for Clean Ganga has entered the Arth Ganga phase where a sustainable development model has been formulated with a focus on economic activities related to the river (such as monetising treated sewage). Under the Namami Gange Programme, 224 of the 406 projects have been completed, accounting for 55 per cent of the sanctioned projects. ■

